

Phishing Awareness Training

Prepared as part of the CodeAlpha Cybersecurity Internship

Most people think they'd never fall for a scam email. The truth is, phishing attacks have gotten a lot better over the last few years, and they don't rely on obvious spelling mistakes anymore. This training walks through what phishing actually looks like today, how attackers trick people into handing over information, and a few habits that make you a much harder target.

1. What Is Phishing?

Phishing is when someone pretends to be a person or company you trust — your bank, your college, a delivery service, even a coworker — in order to get you to click a link, download a file, or type in a password. It usually shows up as an email or text message, but fake login pages and phone calls (sometimes called vishing) work the same way.

The goal is almost always one of these three things: steal your login details, install malware on your device, or trick you into sending money.

2. How to Recognize a Phishing Email

- The sender's email address doesn't quite match the company — e.g. **support@paypa1-secure.com** instead of paypal.com.
- There's pressure to act immediately: "your account will be suspended in 24 hours."
- Links look almost right but aren't — hovering over them (without clicking) shows the real destination in the bottom corner of your browser.
- Generic greetings like "Dear Customer" instead of your actual name.
- Unexpected attachments, especially .zip, .exe, or password-protected files.
- Requests for information a real company would never ask for over email — full card number, OTP, or your password.

A Real-World Style Example

Subject: Unusual sign-in activity detected

From: security-alerts@microsoft-verify.com

Body: "We noticed a login from a new device. If this wasn't you, verify your identity immediately or your account will be locked within 12 hours." — followed by a button labeled **Verify Now** that links to a fake Microsoft login page.

Notice the zero in "micros0ft" and the artificial urgency. This is a classic credential-harvesting phishing email.

3. Fake Websites

Fake websites are usually built to look identical to a real login page — same logo, same colors, sometimes even the same layout copied pixel-for-pixel. What gives them away is usually in the address bar:

- Check the URL carefully. Small changes like **arnazon.com** or **faceb00k.com** are easy to miss at a glance.
- Look for HTTPS and a padlock icon — but note this alone doesn't guarantee safety anymore, since attackers can get certificates too.
- If a site asks you to "log in to view this document" from a link you weren't expecting, be suspicious.
- When unsure, don't click the link at all — open the company's site yourself by typing the address.

4. Social Engineering Tactics

Phishing isn't really a technical attack — it's a psychological one. Attackers rely on a handful of tactics that work on almost everyone if the timing is right:

- **Urgency and fear** — "your account has been compromised," "pay this invoice today or face a late fee."
- **Authority** — pretending to be a manager, IT department, or government agency.
- **Familiarity** — impersonating a coworker or friend, sometimes using a hacked real account.
- **Curiosity** — "see who viewed your profile" or a package tracking link you didn't order.
- **Reciprocity** — offering something free (a gift card, a prize) in exchange for personal details.

5. Best Practices to Avoid Falling Victim

- Pause before clicking. Most phishing relies on you acting fast without thinking.
- Verify through a separate channel — call the company directly using a number from their official site, not the one in the email.
- Never share OTPs or passwords with anyone, even someone claiming to be tech support.
- Turn on two-factor authentication wherever it's offered — it won't stop every attack, but it stops most.
- Keep your browser and antivirus updated; many fake sites get flagged automatically once known.
- If something feels slightly off, trust that instinct and double-check before acting.

6. Quick Quiz

A short self-check to see if the material stuck. Answers are listed below each question.

Q1. You get an email from "Amaz0n-support.com" saying your order is on hold and you must confirm your payment details within 2 hours. What should you do?

- a) Click the link and enter your card details quickly before time runs out
- b) Ignore it and delete the email
- c) Go to Amazon directly by typing the address yourself and check your orders there

Answer: (c) — never act from the email link itself; verify independently.

Q2. A coworker messages you asking for the company Wi-Fi password, but something about the way they're typing feels off. What's the safest move?

- a) Send the password since it's just Wi-Fi
- b) Call or message them through a separate, known channel to confirm it's really them
- c) Ask them to prove it by answering a random question

Answer: (b) — verifying identity through another channel is the safest habit.

Q3. Which of these is the strongest sign of a phishing attempt?

- a) The email has a company logo
- b) The email creates urgency and asks for sensitive information
- c) The email is addressed to you by name

Answer: (b) — urgency plus a request for sensitive info is the biggest red flag.

This training was put together as part of a cybersecurity internship task. Feel free to reuse or adapt it for awareness sessions, orientation material, or personal reference.